

IMPACT OF CRY FIN SMART HEROES (FSH) PROGRAMME IN EASTERN INDIA (2024-2025)



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INTRODUCTION

The Fin Smart Heroes (FSH) programme, a national-level initiative by the Volunteer Engagement Team at Child Rights and You (CRY), aims to enhance financial literacy among school students aged 12 to 15 across India. In its 2024–25 phase, the programme reached over 17,800 students from 97 schools across 6 states through the efforts of 359 trained volunteers. This report highlights the measurable impact of FSH in Eastern India (West Bengal and Assam), the region with the highest volunteer representation (36.2%).

PROGRAMME OUTREACH IN EASTERN INDIA

- **States Covered**: West Bengal and Assam Percentage of National Volunteers from East: 36.2% (highest regional representation)
- **Cities Covered**: Kolkata & Bankura from West Bengal and Jorhat & Kamrup Metropolitan from Assam
- **School Types**: Predominantly government schools, followed by government-aided and a few private institutions
- **Curriculum Boards**: Mostly State Board institutions
- **Gender Representation**: Approximately 52.6% girls and 47.4% boys

The data represents a strong regional foothold, positioning Eastern India as a strategic priority for FSH.

Key Financial Topics Covered:

- Savings and budgeting
- Cybersecurity and fraud awareness
- Loans and interest concepts
- Inflation and income understanding

Volunteers employed interactive methods such as real-life scenarios, quizzes, and visual aids to ensure student engagement and understanding.

METHODOLOGY

➤ Data Source

The primary data for this report is derived from the "Impact of Fin-Smart Heroes Programme in East India (2024-25) Charts & Regional Comparisons" document. This document presents aggregated data in the form of bar charts, showcasing the percentage of correct answers given by students in four regions (North, South, West, and East) on five specific financial literacy topics. It is assumed that this data was collected through standardised assessments administered to student participants of the Fin-Smart Heroes Programme.

➤ Scope of Analysis

The analysis focuses on the comparative performance of students in East India against those in the North, South, and West regions. The report interprets the provided charts to extract quantitative insights regarding the level of understanding for each financial literacy metric. It aims to elaborate on the snapshot of performance, discuss potential implications, and formulate recommendations specifically tailored for the Eastern India context. No raw data or details on sample size, demographic breakdown of participants, or specific assessment questions were available beyond the chart summaries.

➤ Knowledge Assessment and Impact in the Eastern Region

CRY conducted real-time assessments through short situational quizzes during sessions. Results from the East region, compared to national averages, reveal specific insights into financial awareness.

Question Theme	East Correct (%)	National Trends
Piggy Bank (Savings)	12.5	Lowest Nationally
PIN Privacy (Cybersecurity)	54.2	Below average
Loans and Interest	29.2	Below average
Inflation	37.5	Highest Nationally
Detection (lottery)	91.7%	Highest Nationally

➤ Observations:

- Strengths: Exceptional awareness of scams and inflation, likely linked to real-life exposure.
- Weaknesses: Gaps in foundational financial concepts like savings and loans.

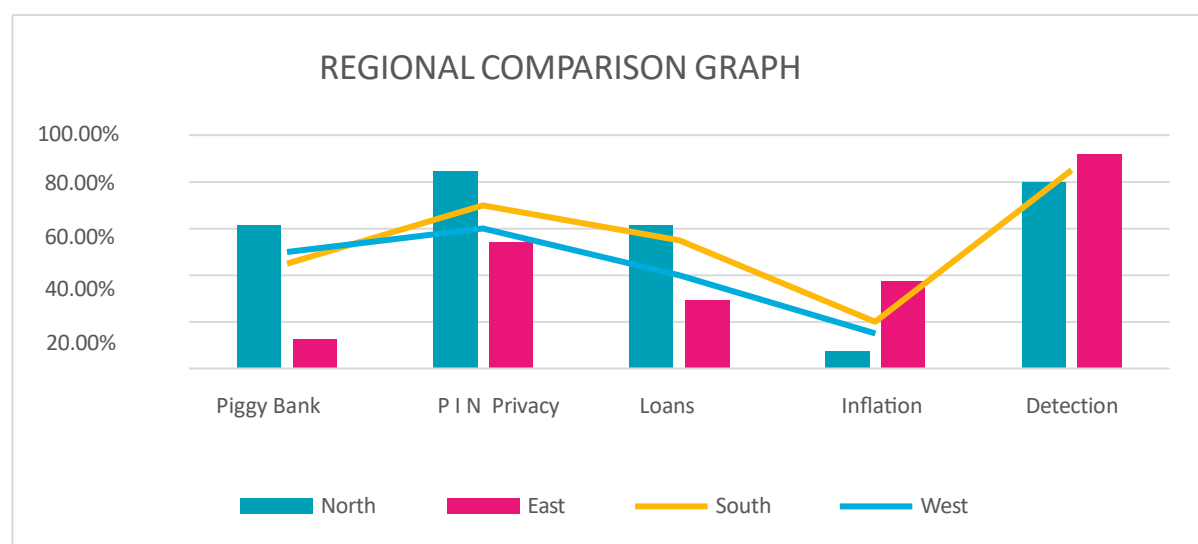
DISCUSSION OF KEY FINDINGS FOR EASTERN INDIA

The analysis of financial literacy metrics for students in East India participating in the Fin-Smart Heroes Programme reveals a distinctive profile characterized by areas of commendable strength alongside significant weaknesses. This necessitates a nuanced understanding to tailor future interventions effectively.

➤ Areas of Strength:

- **Understanding of Inflation:** East India's leading performance in understanding inflation is a remarkable finding. It suggests an aptitude for grasping relatively abstract economic concepts. This could be linked to regional economic discourse, effective teaching of this specific module, or a curriculum that resonates well with students' experiences or observations regarding price changes.
- **Awareness of Online Financial Scams:** The exceptionally high awareness of online financial scams (over 90%) is another major strength. This indicates that students are well-informed about the risks in the digital financial landscape, which is crucial for their safety and security as they increasingly engage with online platforms.

These strengths suggest that students in East India are not inherently lacking in the capacity to learn financial concepts, even complex ones. The programme has evidently been successful in these domains.



These statistics demonstrate that while Eastern India excels in scam detection, its students require more guidance on basic financial tools and practices.

➤ **Areas Requiring Improvement:**

- **Understanding of Savings (Piggy Bank):** The alarmingly low score (around 13%) in understanding basic savings principles is the most critical area of concern. This foundational knowledge is the bedrock upon which other financial skills are built. Without it, concepts like budgeting, investing, and financial planning become difficult to grasp.
- **Understanding of Loans:** Similarly, the low comprehension of loans (around 29%) poses a significant risk. An inability to understand borrowing, interest, and debt management can lead to poor financial decisions and vulnerability to predatory practices.
- **Knowledge of PIN Privacy:** While not as low as savings or loans, the score of 54% in PIN privacy indicates that nearly half the students lack sufficient knowledge about a fundamental security practice. This is somewhat contradictory to the high general awareness of online scams, suggesting a gap between knowing about scams and knowing specific protective actions.

PATH FORWARD

The findings of this report offer a clear roadmap for the Fin-Smart Heroes Programme to refine its strategy in East India. The key lies in adopting a more tailored and adaptive approach that addresses the identified weaknesses directly while leveraging the existing strengths.

Future Outlook and Key Priorities:

- **Curriculum Customisation:** The immediate priority is to revise and enhance curriculum modules related to savings, loans, and PIN privacy, making them more engaging, practical, and contextually relevant for students in East India.
- **Pedagogical Innovation:** Exploring diverse teaching methodologies, including more interactive and experiential learning techniques, will be crucial for improving comprehension and retention of foundational concepts.
- **Continuous Monitoring and Evaluation:** Regular assessments and feedback mechanisms should be an integral part of the programme to track progress, identify emerging challenges, and make ongoing adjustments to the curriculum and delivery methods. This will ensure the programme remains responsive to the evolving needs of the students.
- **Building a Culture of Financial Wellness:** Beyond classroom instruction, efforts should be made to foster a broader culture of financial awareness and responsible money management within schools and communities. This includes engaging parents and leveraging local resources.
- **Research and Deeper Understanding:** Further investigation into the socio-cultural or educational factors contributing to the unique financial literacy profile of East Indian students could yield deeper insights for even more effective programme design.

The Fin-Smart Heroes Programme has a vital role to play in empowering the youth of East India with the financial knowledge and skills necessary to navigate an increasingly complex economic landscape. By addressing the identified gaps with focused interventions and building upon the evident capacity of these students to learn, the programme can serve as a model for scalable, targeted intervention.

CONCLUSION

The CRY Fin Smart Heroes programme has laid a strong foundation for financial literacy among young students in Eastern India. Despite gaps in basic financial understanding, the region's high awareness of digital scams and inflation reflects readiness to evolve. With continued support, localized strategies, and institutional collaboration, Eastern India can become a leader in youth financial empowerment.